

Consonants that can end a word

Not all of the consonants in the Witsuwit'en alphabet are used at the ends of words. In fact, only some of them, roughly two-thirds, can occur there.

Here are all the consonants again (34):

' b c c' d dl dz g gg gh gw h k k' kh kw kw' l lh m n p s t t' ts ts' tl tl' w wh y yh z

Any of the above consonants can occur at the beginning of a word. But only a subset of them (21 consonants) can occur at the end of a word.

' c gh h k kh kw l lh m n p s t ts tl w wh y yh z

(The consonants that can occur at the end of a word are really the consonants that can occur at the end of a syllable in Witsuwit'en. These consonants can also be followed by a consonant.)

K and C

Examples of K

Witsuwit'en **k** is not a sound found in English. Witsuwit'en **k** is produced further back in the mouth (throat) than English *k* (as in *King Kong*).

The sound represented by **k** is a fairly common sound of First Nations languages, especially those spoken on the coast. (Witsuwit'en has it, but Dakelh (Carrier) does not.)

ka	'car'
kë	'footwear'
kambïlh	'rabbit snare'
nenkat	'it snowed'
nikës	'it (vehicle, plate) is going around'
lhikit	'he/she is clapping'

k can occur at the end of a word:

dik, ndik	'straight up'
yik, nyik	'straight down'
nik	'uphill'

Examples of C

Witsuwit'en **c** is kind of like the *c* in English words like *cute*, almost sounding like it has a *y* after it.

can	'rain'
cin	'song'
celh	'young man'
dicin	'wooden, stick'
cinïh	'marten'
Tsë Cakh	'Hagwilget, Tse-Kya'

c can occur at the end of a word:

detic	‘door’
k’intic	‘it’s broken (in two)’
dinī ilhcic	‘police’ (lit. ‘arrest people’)

It can be challenging to distinguishing **c** and **k** at the end of a word. One fact that may help is that of these two sounds, only **c** can be preceded by **ī** or **u**:

bizīc	‘its corpse, dead body’
Midīc	Gidimt’en chief name
lisuc	‘sugar’
yidīznuc	‘he/she hit it with a vehicle’

k cannot be preceded by **ī** or **u** at the end of a word.

K vs. C

Contrasts before a vowel:

bikak ‘its surface’	bicak ‘his/her rib’
skak ‘child’	scak ‘my rib’
bikēn ‘its (ant, beaver, muskrat) lodge’	cēn ‘summer’
bikē ‘his/her foot’	bice ‘its tail’
bikiy ‘her husband’	’atcey/’atciy ‘he/she was buried’
lhakē ‘dogs’	lhic ‘dog’
sikoy ‘he vomited’	’et silhcoz ‘it (cloth) is there’
nikat/nikatnī ‘movable goods’	bicat ‘inside his/her/its stomach’

Contrasts at the end of a word:

binik/bisnik ‘his/her (baby’s) eye’	binic ‘his her nostril, sense of smell’
dīk, ndīk ‘up’	dic ‘well’ ⁴
bit’ik ‘his/her collarbone; its fin’	binit’ic ‘his/her muscle’

Words with both C and K

kecip	‘spoon’
bicak	‘his/her rib’
cilkē	‘young men’
tacēk	‘mouth of river’

⁴as in: dic, ’en ’alha’ ’itnī ‘well, he’s right’

Many Witsuwit'en words that might seem to begin with a vowel actually begin with ' (a sound that linguists call *glottal stop*).⁵ ' can occur before a vowel, before a consonant, or at the end of a word. Between vowels is probably the easiest place to recognize the sound:

tse'alh	'pillow'
gwe'ilh	'bag'
si'ët	'without me'
bik'ë'et	'less than it'
yi'ey	'it' (variant of 'ey)
Sa'on	Tsayu chief name

' after a vowel, at the end of a word:

be'	'fully dried fish'
de'	'downriver'
ku'	'puppy'
mī'	'berry'
hë'	'all right'
ka'	'heck no, don't'
'et de'	'back then'
'en co'?	'what about him?'

' after a vowel, before a consonant:

c'ide'nī	'ancestors'
ho'ggec	'nothing'
lha'digegh	'he's finished'
ne'dil'a'	'he hired himself'
Du'bis	Likhsilyu chief name

After a consonant and before a vowel, ' tends to disappear (except in careful speech) (this would be the only "silent letter" in Witsuwit'en spelling). Compare:

yī'ën	'he/she sees it'
ts'ë'ën	'we see it'
vs.	
īs'ën	'I see it'
īn'ën	'you see it'

' is still written in the latter pair, because ' is pronounced in careful speech, and ë is a vowel that does not otherwise occur after **n**.

⁵Some words in Witsuwit'en do in fact begin with a vowel. The only vowels that can begin a word are **u** and **ī**. More on this below.

' vs. H

h is another glottal sound. Here are some contrasts between ' and **h** at the beginning of a word:

hots hanye 'he/she came from there'
hont'iy' 'he's happy'

'anye 'he/she went in a hole'
'unt'iy' (~ 'ont'iy') 'he's proud'

h vs. ' at the end of a word:

bighih 'its roots'
cinih 'marten'
nuh 'upriver in general area'
hadih 'hello, hi'

bighi' 'its grease'
ts'inī' 'paternal grandmother' (talking to her)
nu' 'upriver'
~ hadi' 'hello, hi'

' vs. nothing

Here are some contrasts between words which end with ' and words which end with a vowel. ' after a vowel cuts off the vowel, making it shorter.

sa' 'long time'
nu' 'upriver'
honzu' 'it became good'
witsiy' 'badness, bad weather'
bighu' 'his (baby's) teeth'
nye' 'your lice'
sle niwes'a' 'he hasn't shaken my hand'

sa 'sun'
nu 'island'
honzu 'it's good'
nitsiy 'crest'
bighu 'his teeth'
niye 'he's walking around'
sle ni'a 'he's shaking my hand'

Remember that only two of the vowels of Witsuwit'en can occur at the beginning of a word, **u** and **ī**. Here are some contrasts between words which begin with 'u and those which begin with **u**:

'unist'iy' (~ 'onist'iy') 'I'm proud'
'usa 'pot'
'ugunī 'porcupine'
'uslus, 'usdlus 'toboggan'

unist'iy' 'I like it'
uye 'shy'
ugildiw 'I could count, let me count'
wighe usdlī, wighe uslī 'I'm not allowed'

T'

t' is another sound of Witsuwit'en which is not found in English. **t'** and other sounds spelled with ' are common in First Nations languages. In Witsuwit'en **t'** must be followed by a vowel. **t'** does not occur at the end of a word or before another consonant.

Examples of T'

t'alh
t'ēs
t'aco

'food'
'charcoal'
'mallard'

t'ak'ët
t'ighis
c'it'an
yit'as
bit'akh

'autumn'
'aspen'
'leaf, bush'
'he/she is cutting it'
'under it (table)'

T' vs. T

t'ëkh 'raw'
bit'ak 'his/her back'
ninit'a 'she's looking around'
bit'ay 'his/her chest'
nit'ay 'berry; it's getting ripe'
wedint'ic 'it's tied up'

tëkh 'into, under water'
bintak 'his/her forehead'
ninita 'she's searching'
bitay 'his paternal uncle'
ditay 'it's thick, deep'
k'intic 'it's broken (in 2)'

T' vs. D

st'ë 'it cooked (over heat)'
nt'ik 'your collarbone'
dicin dilht'im 'it's gnawing wood'
wedint'ic 'it's tied up' (dog, boat)
yizt'is 'he cut it (once)'
nilt'ikw 'soon, shortly'

'et sde 'he/she is sitting there'
ndik 'straight up'
bidzi dildim 'his heart is pounding'
yendic 'there was a meeting, phone call'
yizdiz~yinzdis 'he gave it a twist'
nizdikw 'it's spherical, round'

Words with T', T and/or D in them

t'ët
t'ëdiku
c'it'it
ditni
dit'ay
yintëstat

'young lady, teenage girl'
'young ladies, teenage girls'
'she's smoking'
'groundhog, marmot'
'duck'
'he has a craving for it'

KH vs. H

kh is one of the back of the throat sounds found in Witsuwit'en but not English.

Examples of KH

kh occurs before a vowel:

khëlh
khas
khiy

'pack'
'fireweed'
'root'

kh also occurs word-finally:

yikh
net'ikh
dilkw'akh
khikh

'house'
'spruce grouse, fool hen'
'frog'
'goose'

Examples of *H*

h is a sound of English as well as Witsuwit'en. However, unlike English, in Witsuwit'en **h** can occur at the end of a word.

h before a vowel

hë 'okay, all right'
 hëkw 'go ahead'
 hots 'over there'
 halho 'cloth'
 hinic 'language'
 hiwal 'clan donation'
 hët'il 'cedar'

h at the end of a word

gguh	'deadfall'
bizuh	'by him/her'
c'ikwah	'river'
cinih	'marten'
dinih	'kinnikinnik'
'anih	'come'
lek'oh	'I don't know'

KH vs. H

These sounds are similar except that **kh** has more noise and friction than **h**.

kh vs. **h** before a vowel:

khiz 'pus'	hiztëz 'they're lying down'
khë 'grease'	hëdilh 'they're walking'
khilh 'darkness; club'	hilhtis 'he/she is strong'
khiyt, khīt 'winter'	hida 'moose'

kh vs. **h** at the end of a word:

ts'ëkh 'sinew'	tsëh 'first'
bit'akh 'under it'	'it'ah 'he/she is working'
'enlekh 'make it'	'et senleh 'leave them there'
tëkh 'into, under water'	'et weytëh 'he/she isn't lying there'
niyekh 'he/she is growing'	biwewdichhyeh 'I don't know it'

Writing practice 3

_____	'louse'
_____	'fog'
_____ or _____	'star'
_____	'diaper'
_____	'across'
_____	'file'
_____	'he/she is eating (something)'
_____	'straight'
_____	'6'
_____	'wire, cable'
_____	'it's chewing it'
_____	'it itches'
_____	'inside his/her mouth'
_____	'tiptoe'
_____	'his/her dog'
_____	'his/her dogs'

When you have finished, compare what you wrote with your neighbor and try to come to some agreement.

Answers to writing practice 3

ye

'a

sim/sin

tsil

lhë'

k'az

c'i'alh

ts'e'in

gïstan

ïtggis

yilhghis

hilhghïs

bizek

këledzec

bilic

bilekë'

'louse'

'fog'

'star'

'diaper'

'across'

'file'

'he/she is eating (something)'

'straight'

'6'

'wire, cable'

'it's chewing it'

'it itches'

'inside his/her mouth'

'tiptoe'

'his/her dog'

'his/her dogs'